

people for whom you did the trades. But that will be bad for your reputation and business even if you get away with lighter punishment.'

I thought about it. There was no easy way out.

'What do you suggest, Govindbhai?'

'Retreat for the time being if it helps sate somebody's sense of revenge. I can call in a few favours and ensure that you don't come to harm legally. When things clear, you can always return. After all, there are no permanent friends or enemies in this market,' he said.

My exit was not on the high note I would have liked it to be. Things happened a little too quickly to allow me to plan out my next course of action. The big boys of the trade and a few close friends knew my hand had been forced. But to most acquaintances I was retiring at the top of my game, to try my hand at something more challenging.

'I envy you, Lala,' many a friend would tell me, 'it takes guts to say "I have had enough of the market".'

Through a combination of discipline and good fortune, I had ensured that money would be the least of my concerns. There was enough to last me a lifetime and more, so long as I did not crave a private beach or an island in the Caribbean. But money alone was not the answer to everything, as I always knew. Here I was, in the prime of my life at 46, with no clear idea as to what to do next. Other than guessing with a fair degree of accuracy where stock prices were heading, I had no other real skill to speak of.

A few friends suggested that I manage the portfolios of HNIs. The catch here was that I would have to do that unofficially, since I had agreed to stay away from the market. But there was no denying that I was known in the market and that there were enough people who could do with my services. A few promoters and even a couple of big names of Dalal Street sounded me out, but I was fussy about whom I would now work with or for.

'How long do you intend to enjoy your retired life?' GB asked, when I had gone over to his place for dinner at his invitation.

I immediately sensed that he must have thought of something for me.

'Let me hear out your proposal, and I shall decide,' I told him, smiling.

GB started with surprise, then chuckled.

'Always alert, whether or not in front of the screen, Lala; that is what I like about you,' he said, and told me what he had in mind. A leading industrialist wanted me to manage the share prices of his group companies